Dr. Fritz

By David Ives

MARIA: *is sitting behind a crude plank table made from an old door*
TOM: *enters, bent over at the waist, holding his side and gasping in pain.*

TOM: Eugh. Eugh. Eugh.

MARIA: Bendio, sinhors! Comari ta? How you are feeling todays?

TOM: Eugh.

MARIA: You want to buy a souvenirs? One of a kinds

TOM: Eugh. I'm looking for Dr. Fritz.

MARIA: Ah, Dr. Fritz can cure everything. You have a troothache?

TOM: No. Poison.

MARIA: You have been poisoned? Tsk, tsk, tsk, tsk.

TOM: Food poisoning.

MARIA: Oh, the food poisonings. But no troothache? I was foretold of a man named Pablo corning with a troothache.

TOM: I'm not Pablo.

MARIA: This is why you have no troothache.

INTRODUCTION

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TOM: Look. . . My name is Tom Sanders. At the hotel I talked to this man, Pedro. . . Pedro said come here and ask for Dr. Fritz.

MARIA: Ah, Dr. Fritz can cure everything. Broken bone, bullet hole, burn, amputation, housemaid's knee.

TOM: But

MARIA: Terminal diseases is more difficult.

TOM: But

MARIA: This is why they are called terminal.

TOM: But

MARIA: Ah, but are they terminal? A case for Dr. Fritz.

TOM: But-doesn't the sign say "BUTCHER"?

MARIA: You speak the languages so good.

TOM: Eugh.

MARIA: Now this is the souvenir shop of Maria and the offices of Dr. Fritz.

TOM: (pain) Jesus Christ. . . ! Is he here?

MARIA: Jesus are everywhere.

TOM: Dr. Fritz.

MARIA: Oh, Dr. Fritz.

TOM: Wait a minute. You're not Dr. Fritz. . . ?

MARIA: I am the assistant of Dr. Fritz. (laughs madly; then calm again) At the moment.

TOM: Oh God. ..

MARIA: Good! You believe in God.

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TOM: No I don't believe in God.

MARIA: But sinhors, you called on God, you said, Oh God,oh God.

TOM: It was a figure of speech, okay?

MARIA: Just checking. [We hear a ringing, like a telephone.]

TOM: What's that?

MARIA: What is what, sinhors? [RING.] I hear nothings. [RING.] Maybe the food poisoning make you a little lococo. [RING.]

TOM: Don't you hear that bell?

MARIA: Oh, the bells. (picks up a souvenir doll and speaks into it like a telephone) Mushi mushi . . . Si . . . Si . . . Si . . . - Dosveedonyeh. (hangs up the doll) This was Pedro. He say you are on the way. [Tom picks up the doll and looks at it.] There is always more meat than meets the eyes meat, no?

TOM: I must have fever.

MARIA: Are you shvitzing?

TOM: I am shvitzing. Look, if I die, tell them this.

MARIA: We all will die, sinhors-God willing.

TOM: Last night I ate supper at the hotel. Middle of the night I thought I was going to die.

MARIA: You know I think this every day, but here I am. God willing.

TOM: Maria. I don't want Dr. Fritz anymore.

MARIA: No?

TOM: No. I just want to die.

MARIA: No, no, no, no, sinhors. Don't you see, the world are a great battle between the forces of the light, and the forces of

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the darkness. You must always stay on the side of the forces of light.

TOM: I need a doctor! [RING.]

MARIA: (picks up the doll and speaks into it) Bonjour. Si. Si. Si. Si. No. Ciao. (hangs up) This was God. He say you should believe in him.

TOM: Where is he?

MARIA: God? Upstairs.

TOM: I'm getting out of here. (starts out, but is stopped by pain) Eugh.

MARIA: Ah, but where will you go, sinhors? And how will you get there in your present conditions? [Tom sinks down and lies on the floor.]

TOM: So this is where I'm going to die. I'm going to die here, I'm going to die here, I'm going to die-!

MARIA/DR. FRITZ: (German accent) Quiet! You miserable dog! You spineless beast!"

TOM: What...?

MARIA/DR. FRITZ: Shut up, you confounded worm! Or else die! Go ahead! Die! What does it matter to me?

TOM: What's going on here. . . ?

MARIA/DR. FRITZ: (German accent) "I am dying, I am dying!" Ja, ja, perhaps you are dying. If I can shtop this dying I vill shtop it. I am not a magician. I am a physician. But you must listen, ja? You are listening? Ja?

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TOM: Ja.

MARIA/DR. FRITZ: Gut. I am Dr. Fritz Ringsvwant'l. How do you do. So. Get up.

TOM: What?

MARIA/DR. FRITZ: Shtand up on your footses.

TOM: I-I can't. . .

MARIA/DR. FRITZ: Get up, you lazy pig! Move! Move!" [Tom gets up.] I can't get up! You people. Too many Coca-Colas, it has eaten your brains. You haff no will anymore. Too much of ze French fries nut ketchup at ze Golden Arches von McDonald's. (looks in each of Tom's eyes quickly) Zoo You haffze conztipation zometimes, ja?

TOM: I do have the constipation sometimes.

MARIA/DR. FRITZ: Und zometimes maybe you get a little prickly shtinging pain just behind ze Ellenbogen, hier, hmm? ("Ellenbogen" is "elbow.")

TOM: I do get a little prickly pain right there.

MARIA/DR. FRITZ: Und you haff ze very ugly dandruff. You must use Head und Shoulders. Giff me your hand! Schnell! (takes Tom's hand and feels the pulse) Your pulse is normal.

TOM: You're not wearing a watch.

MARIA/DR. FRITZ: Your eyesight is excellent. Open your mouth. Stick out your tongue. Go like this. [He makes a raspberry. Tom does too.] No, like this. [Another raspberry. Tom does too.] Better. Now put your fingers in your ears. Can you hear me?

TOM: What?

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MARIA/DR. FRITZ: Good. (slaps him on the top of the head)

TOM: Ow!

MARIA/DR. FRITZ: Ziss is a poor country, Meine Herren. I haff nothing here! Nothing! (feels Tom's forehead quickly) Besidesyou haff no fever. You are sure you haff no troothache!

TOM: I DON'T HAVE A TROOTHACHE!

MARIA/DR. FRITZ: Just checking. But at four you had ze rheumatic fever. Ja?

TOM: I did have rheumatic fever. . .

MARIA/DR. FRITZ: At fifteen you had a rash on your butttocks in ze shape of Santa Claus. At twenty you had rhinitis, bronchitis, conjunctivitis, and gonorrhea-a busy year for you. At twenty-two you had ze doppel pneumonia and you thought you were going to die.

TOM: Wow.

MARIA/DR. FRITZ: VOW indeed. You zleep every day from 12:34 to T 38 in the morning. You eat usually eggs and toast mit raspberry shmier for breakfast, ze garbage fast food for lunch, maybe ze wiener made from pig balls or a slice of Scheisse you call pizza. At ze nighttimes you eat in a restaurant, sometimes Chinese, sometimes Italian, you haff ze gnorchis mit mushrooms und ze shmall green zalat.

TOM: Amazing.

MARIA/DR. FRITZ: Ziss is your entire shtupid life.

TOM: So what's wrong with me?

MARIA/DR. FRITZ: (Dr. Fritz straps Tom to the table.) I haff no idea. Lie down.

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TOM: How do you know all these things about me?

MARIA/DR. FRITZ: I am a highly qualified sturgeon.

MARIA/DR. FRITZ: Zympathetic reaction. You vant to buy a zoovenirs?

TOM: No.

MARIA/DR. FRITZ: Vun ofa kinds. (Maria/Dr. Fritz lays the doll on Tom's sternum.)

TOM: OWW!

MARIA/DR. FRITZ: Your case is not so complicated. You need an operation.

TOM: An operation. . . ?

MARIA/DR. FRITZ: Immediately.

TOM: You're kidding. Not here. Not in this town.

MARIA/DR. FRITZ: You zee another town? (produces some ugly-looking butcher knives) Unfortunately, I haff not the proper tools. . .

TOM: (struggling in the bands) No. No ...!

MARIA/DR. FRITZ: I haff no anaesthetic; ziss could be quite painful. (starts sharpening one of the knives)

TOM: But I'm fine! I'm fine!

MARIA/DR. FRITZ: Fine? Nein.

TOM: Put that thing down!

MARIA/DR. FRITZ: Okay. You are fine? Then good. (undoes the straps) Go. You are free. I am not a torturer, I am a doctor. So go. Go! Tom gets up, turns and starts to go, but is stopped by a sudden pain that drops him to his knees.

TOM: Eugh. Eugh. Oh God. . . !

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MARIA/DR. FRITZ: You believe in God? Do you not realize the place you have come to? The forces arrayed vhich could crush you like a peanut? Tom whimpers. Thunderclap. You have finished your good works, I hope.

TOM: No! I haven't done anything! I've eaten hot dogs made from pig balls and I had a rash on my butt and that's it.

MARIA/DR. FRITZ: This is not very much. Alas, now ze great battle is joined, Meine Herren, and you are in the middle of the field. Ze forces of light and ze forces of darkness are fighting for you. I only hope zatt you vill find your way to the forces of light very very soon.

TOM: But how?

MARIA/DR. FRITZ: Good kvestion. RING Ogh. Ziss doll has been ringing off ze hook all day. (picks up the doll and speaks into it:) Pronto. Si. Si. Si. Si. (to Tom) It is for you.

TOM: For me . . . ?

MARIA/DR. FRITZ: Ja. God vants to talk to you. [Tom makes a gesture to say: "I'm not here."]Here. Take it. Be nice. Ziss iss God.

TOM: (takes the doll and speaks into it:) Hello...? Yes, this is he . . . Fine. Actually, I'm not feeling so fine, I have a pain in my . . . (realizing the pain is gone:) Well, I thought I had a pain. . . But you know, it's kind of amazing talking to you like this, so listen, urn, God, while I've got you on the line-no, no, no, I understand, you've got other things. I just thought I'd get in a few questions. You know-meaning of life, your general

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take on things, etcetera. So great. I'll see you later-much later. I hope. Nice talking to you. 'Bye. (puts the doll down)

MARIA: (Hispanic again, knitting) You are feeling better? How you are feeling, sinhors?

TOM: I feel fantastic. . . !

MARIA: That so nice. (holds up doll) Souvenirs?

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AWARD HISTORY

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